

The Seat by the Window

An original short story for the Point of View unit.

MONDAY

Theo and I have shared the same bus seat since third grade. Fourth row, left side, the seat by the window. I get bus sick, so I always take the window. Theo never complains, even though the window is the best spot on the whole bus.

So on Monday, four days before the science fair, I climbed on and found him way in the back, in the seat over the wheels. Alone. His backpack sat beside him like a guard dog.

I waved. He gave me a small wave back and went right back to writing in a little green notebook.

I sat in our seat by myself. The window felt cold against my forehead.

Maybe it was the joke. Last Friday at lunch, I told everyone about his volcano project from fourth grade, the one that erupted all over a judge's shoes. Everyone laughed. Theo laughed too. At least, I thought he did.

TUESDAY

On Tuesday he sat in the front row, right behind Ms. Pell, our bus driver. They talked the whole ride. Once, Ms. Pell looked at me in her big mirror and smiled. Then Theo wrote something in the green notebook.

Great, I thought. Now the bus driver is in on it too.

At lunch I asked about his science fair project. He had kept it a secret since September.

"You'll see Friday," he said. He didn't look up from his sandwich.

WEDNESDAY

On Wednesday, Theo sat in the middle of the bus next to two eighth graders I don't even know. He asked them questions and wrote down everything they said.

He also held a plastic cup of water on his knee. He had drawn a line on the side with a marker. He stared at that cup the whole ride like it was the best show on TV. Every time we hit a bump, he scribbled something down.

When the bus stopped at school, I finally walked back to his seat.

"Are you mad at me?"

He looked surprised. "What? No." Then he looked down at his cup. "I just can't sit with you this week. I'll explain later."

"Later" is what people say when they mean "never."

THURSDAY

Thursday was the worst. Theo sat in the very last row. Everybody knows the back of the bus is the bumpiest. By the time we got to school, his face was the color of old cheese. He held the green notebook against his chest like a shield.

I almost went back to check on him. But he had made it pretty clear that he didn't want me around. So I stared out my window and pretended I didn't care.

FRIDAY

The science fair was in the gym on Friday night. I stood next to my paper airplane project and answered a judge's questions. The whole time, I kept looking across the room for Theo.

His table was at the end of the last row. At the top of his board, in big letters, it said: **THE SEAT BY THE WINDOW: WHERE SHOULD YOU SIT IF YOU GET BUS SICK?**

There was a map of our bus with a colored dot on every row. There was a chart showing how much his cup of water sloshed in each seat. There was a quote from Ms. Pell: "The front bounces the least. Tell your friend to look out at the road ahead."

At the bottom, he had written: Best seat: front row, by the window. Worst seat: last row. (I tested it. Trust me.)

I read the whole board twice.

Theo walked up behind me, holding two cups of punch. He handed me one.

"You could have told me," I said.

"Then it wouldn't be a surprise." He shrugged. "Also, you would have tried to sit in the back with me."

He was right. I would have.

On Monday, I climbed on the bus and headed for the fourth row. Theo was already sitting up front, behind Ms. Pell. He slid over and patted the spot by the window.

"Data says it's yours," he said.

I sat down. The glass was warm from the sun.